

Triumphs and losses

Even with rudimentary technology, around 25 tunnels and eight viaducts were built in the area from cutting about 1.5 million cubic metres of rock and embanking 1.8 million cubic metres of material. The enterprise, however, came at a terrible human price. Constructing bridges and tunnels in the mountains required rocks to be drilled and blasted. For this, workers were often suspended by ropes. Many lost their grip only to fall to instantaneous death in the ravines below. Work often came to a halt due to extreme weather – from heavy rainfall and strong winds to arid, dry heat. Those who managed to brave the weather and escape accidents were lost to diseases such as typhoid, smallpox, and malaria, to name a few. A massive cholera outbreak in 1860 killed around 25 per cent of the Europeans and innumerable Indian workers. Construction was further delayed because of severed labour relations due to discrimination and terrible working conditions.

The Bhore Ghat line finally opened to traffic in 1863 and Thul Ghat in 1865. It is estimated that about 25,000 Indian workers died during the eight years it took to construct the line, which is still in use today. The reversing station was retired in 1929 when the Bombay–Poona line was electrified and a straight line was laid from the Monkey Hill station in Bhore Ghat to Khandala.